unanimously. Keep the document in the Defense Ministry. Ratify it after receiving F[idel] Castro's consent." Mikoyan's criticism had had some impact. He now hoped that Castro would refuse and that Biriuzov would find the Cuban terrain unsuitable for concealing missiles.[12]

Before the meeting was adjourned and the participants went their separate ways, Khrushchev delivered his concluding remarks, summarizing his argument for placing nuclear missiles in Cuba. Alekseev recalled Khrushchev's words decades later: "To avenge their defeat at Playa Girón, the Americans will undertake an intervention in Cuba not with the help of mercenaries but with their own armed forces: we have reliable information to that effect." He continued: "They must be given to understand that, in attacking Cuba, they will be dealing not only with one stubborn country but also with the nuclear might of the Soviet Union. The price of a military venture against Cuba must be raised to the maximum, and in some measure the threat to Cuba must be made comparable to the threat to the United States. Logic suggests … that only the installation of our rockets with nuclear warheads on Cuban territory can be such a means."[13]

According to Alekseev, Khrushchev did not stop with the "save Cuba" argument but went on to address the disparity of Soviet and American nuclear arsenals, maintaining that the installation of Soviet missiles in Cuba would redress the balance of nuclear terror. "Since the Americans have already surrounded the Soviet Union with a ring of their military bases and multipurpose missile installations, we should pay them back in their own coin and give them a taste of their own medicine so that they find out for themselves how it feels to live as a target of nuclear arms," argued Khrushchev. He specifically mentioned the American missiles in Europe and Turkey. The Jupiter missiles in Turkey were of special concern to Marshal Malinovsky, who had warned Khrushchev earlier that they could reach Soviet territory within ten minutes. While a Soviet ballistic missile response to the American Minuteman was years away, the Jupiter could be countered immediately by placing Soviet missiles in Cuba. Khrushchev clearly did not want to lose the opportunity.[14]

Furthermore, Khrushchev considered that such a response to the American nuclear threat was unlikely to provoke a nuclear war: after all, the Soviets had accepted the installation of American missiles in Turkey